The setting up of the NDC can be considered as the step in India towards decentralised planning.

(iii) In the constitutional design of the federal rigidities it was necessary to provide the whole planning process a unified outlook. The NDC serves the purpose of diluting the autonomous and rigid federal units of the Union of India.[62]

The basic nature, legal status and other details of the NDC are same except its composition and functions. It is composed of all the members of the PC, the Union Cabinet, the Chief Ministers of the States, the Administrators/Lt. Governors of the Union Territories (UTs). The PM, naturally, chairs its meetings. The cabinet Resolution by which the NDC was set up defines its functions[63] which are as under:

(i) to consider the proposals formulated for Plans at all important stages and accept them;

(ii) to review the working of the Plans from time to time;

(iii) to consider the important questions of social and economic policy affecting national development; and

(iv) to recommend measures for the achievement of the aims and targets set out in the national Plan, including measures to secure the ***active participation*** and co-operation of the people, improve the efficiency of the administrative services, ensure the fullest development of the less advanced regions and backward sections of the community and through sacrifices borne equally by all citizens, build up resources for national development.[64]

Though the first Plan of India was launched before the arrival of the NDC, the body had many meetings before the terminal year of the plan and useful deliberations (almost all) after due consideration were included by the Government into the planning process. But after the death of J.L. Nehru—the greatest champion of the democratic decentralisation in the country[65] the NDC had become a small gathering of only those who had the same vested interests with only the Congress CMs participating in its meetings. The CMs belonging to other political parties usually did not come to its meetings the Government hardly gave any importance to their advice. A phase of tussle between the centre and the states started worsening from